It also has six industrial sectors today, double the number it had in 2017.

"Almost 800 acres of land has been acquired for industries in the past five years," says GIDA CEO Pavan Agarwal. "We are allotting it to various industries.... We are developing industrial areas around the Gorakhpur Link Expressway and also around the Gorakhpur-Lucknow highway." There are also plans to set up a new 6,000-acre satellite town called 'New Gorakhpur', which will have residential as well as commercial complexes. Other new townships are in the pipeline too.

The infrastructure push is attracting business. Or at least the intent. At the Uttar Pradesh Global Investors Summit held in Lucknow in February this year, Gorakhpur attracted investment worth Rs 1.7 lakh crore, in fourth position after Gautam Buddh Nagar, Agra and Lucknow. Key projects include a proposed LPG pipeline worth Rs 1,800 crore by the Indian Oil Corporation, the RG Strategy Group's Rs 2,935 crore funding for a paper mill project, Rs 1,200 crore committed by Keyaan Distilleries, and Rs 1,100 crore by Varun Beverages, a subsidiary of PepsiCo. Tatva Plastics, CP Milks and India Glycol Limited are a few other key investors. Also on the cards is a 'plastic park', one of Yogi's dream projects, which is expected to come up at a cost of Rs 93 crore. Spread over 50 acres, it will house around a hundred units that will be involved in a range of plastic processing ventures from supply to recycling. Five acres under the project have been earmarked for the Central Institute of Petrochemicals Engineering and Technology to set up a testing laboratory.

In addition to these projects, the Gorakhpur fertiliser plant, which had to be shut down in 1990 due to an ammonia gas leak that claimed an employee's life, has also been restarted at a cost of nearly Rs 8,600 crore. Separately, Avada Ventures, which participated in the investors' summit in February, has signed an MoU to commit Rs 22,500 crore for setting up a green ammonia plant in the city.

"Gorakhpur is now becoming a hub for industries in Purvanchal," says Agarwal. "We are getting new investments. Several units have been started. From next year, our ambitious project, the plastic park, will be functional. We are also allotting plots in flatted factories [small units located in multi-storeyed buildings] mainly for garments manufacturing work."

Not just Gorakhpur's industrial status, its civic identity too is getting an upgrade. In just the first year of Yogi's second term, the city bagged development funding worth Rs 12,000 crore, a big share of which went towards infrastructural revamping. "Gorakhpur's infrastructure development is in full swing. We are planning several new townships, a sports city and a new convention centre.... The CM's vision plays an important role in it," says Mahendra Singh Tanwar, vice-chairman of the Gorakhpur Development Authority (GDA).





"ONCE INFAMOUS FOR ITS MOSQUITOS AND MAFIA, GORAKHPUR IS NOW KNOWN FOR DEVELOPMENT"

YOGI ADITYANATH
UP chief minister, speaking in August 2022



SPREADING ITS WINGS
(top) flyover at Kalesar zero point in Gorakhpur; boating at Ramgarh lake